Did enfranchisement lead to representation?

Gailius Praninskas and Ellen Munroe

London School of Economics

Job market paper

15 October 2026

Politicians are much wealthier than the people they represent

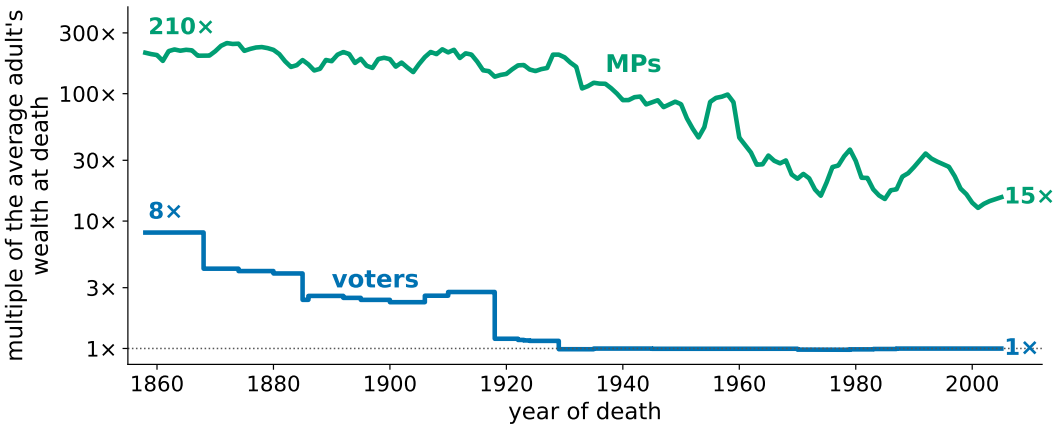


Different policies?

Plutocracy back?

Today, the household of the mean national legislator is around 70 times wealthier than the mean household in their country (Motolinia, Klašnja and Weschle 2026).

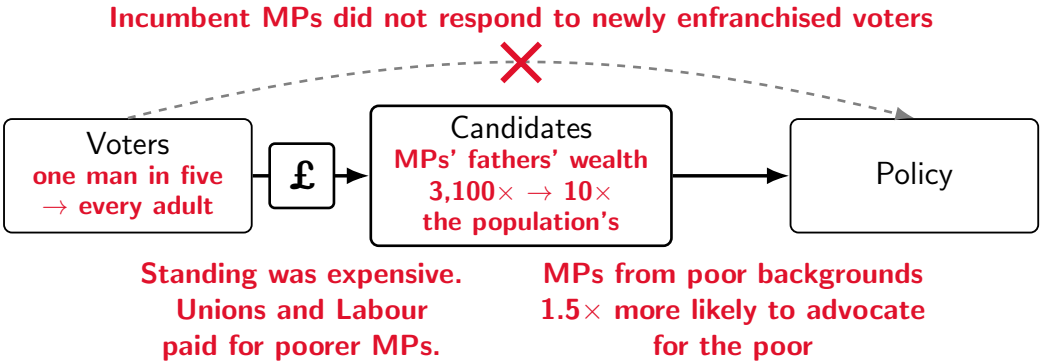
In Britain, this gap narrowed after poorer people got the right to vote



Did enfranchisement lead to representation?

- **Setting.** England and Wales, 1858–1990. In 1858, a plutocracy. One man in five could vote; four in five MPs died above 99th wealth percentile
- **Measure.** Probate (wealth-at-death) records for MPs, their fathers, voters and population.
- **Shock.** Four extensions of the vote, 1867 to 1928, each enfranchising poorer people. Identification from timing across cohorts and constituencies
- **Question.** Did enfranchisement lead to political representation?
  - Descriptive: did MPs become more similar to the population in wealth?
  - Substantive: did Parliament advocate and pass laws for the newly enfranchised?
- **Findings.** Yes, both. Enfranchisement changed policy through who was elected. **Mechanism**: standing was expensive, so poorer MPs could enter only once unions and Labour paid their costs.

Findings: how enfranchisement led to representation, 1858-1990



Main Contributions

Wealth of politicians and voters throughout process of democratisation

Enfranchisement $\Rightarrow$ political selection $\Rightarrow$ broad substantive representation

- **Transition from plutocracy to common-interest state**: policy changed when the poor were elected, not immediately at enfranchisement

  Besley and Persson 2011; Acemoglu and Robinson 2000, 2008; Lizzeri and Persico 2004

- **Political selection**: enfranchisement brought MPs from poor backgrounds into Parliament

  Dal Bó et al. 2017; Carnes and Lupu 2023; Berlinski et al. 2014; Feigenbaum et al. 2026

- **Representation**: separate whether enfranchisement affected policy through changes in who was elected or through changing the behaviour of sitting MPs

  Besley and Coate 1997; Osborne and Slivinski 1996; Lee et al. 2004; Pande 2003; Corvalán et al. 2020

- **Financial barriers to office**: complementarity between enfranchisement and campaign financing

  Besley 2004; Fouirnaies 2021; Cagé 2025; Motolinia, Klašnja and Weschle 2026

Outline

1. Historical Context and Data

2. Four facts about representation, 1858–1990

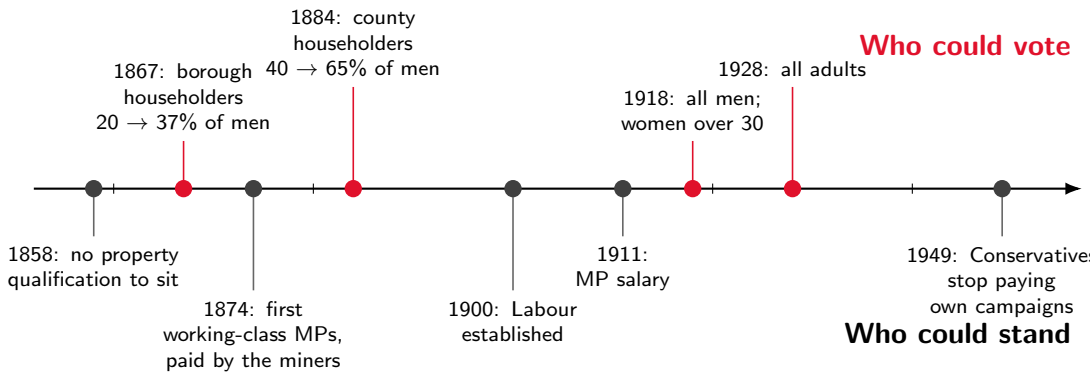
3. Did changes in franchise cause representation?

4. Did financial constraints keep poorer MPs out of politics?

5. Conclusion

Setting: property franchise and the cost of standing in Britain

Before 1867: 1832 property franchise, one man in five can vote



Before 1858: MPs must own property, pay for their own campaigns, no wage

We measure representation by MP fathers' wealth, relative to population

Why wealth

- Both who could vote and who could stand were determined by wealth
- Many policies directly affect wealth, policy positions depend on wealth
  (Pande 2003; Carnes 2013)
- Only continuous economic measure for whole population, 1858–1990

Why the father's

- Own wealth-at-death partly reflects returns to office and ability
  (Eggers and Hainmueller 2009)
- A father's wealth-at-death reflects both the wealth MP had access to at the start of career and background

▸ Property franchise ▸ Not occupation? ▸ Father death timing

Data

- **Probate calendars, 1858–1990:** wealth-at-death, England and Wales, 17 million records
- **Death registers, 1858–1990:** everyone who died, 71 million records NEW MERGE
- **MPs and fathers, 1858–2024:** biographical information for every deceased MP NEW COLLECTION
- **Candidates, 1832–2018:** nearly every candidacy
- **Parliamentary speeches, 1858–2005:** 5.9 million speeches, each debate classified by type, statutory incidence and issue NEW MERGE & CLASSIFICATION
- **Opinion polls, 1955–1991:** Polls on what voters wanted of government by class
- **Constituencies, 1858–1990:** wealth distributions by constituency NEW

Probate calendars. Descriptive representation

CHURCHILL James of Buckland St. Mary Somerset labourer died 28 January 1894 Probate **Taunton** 13 February to James Churchill blacksmith Effects £10.

£890

CHURCHILL the right honourable Randolph Henry Spencer (commonly called lord Randolph Henry Spencer **CHURCHILL**) of 50 Grosvenor-square London died 24 January 1895 Probate **London** 28 February to the honourable Jennie Spencer Churchill commonly called lady Randolph Henry Spencer Churchill widow and the honourable George Richard Penn commonly called viscount Curzon Effects £75971 3*s.* 3*d.*

£6.8 million

CHURCHILL Robert of Blackwater Buckland St. Mary Somerset road contractor died 14 November 1895 Probate **Taunton** 12 December to Samuel James Hoare farmer and Walter Wyatt tailor Effects £18 14*s.* 1*d.*

£1,700

Manually match all MPs (and their fathers) who died from 1858 to 2024 to a probate.

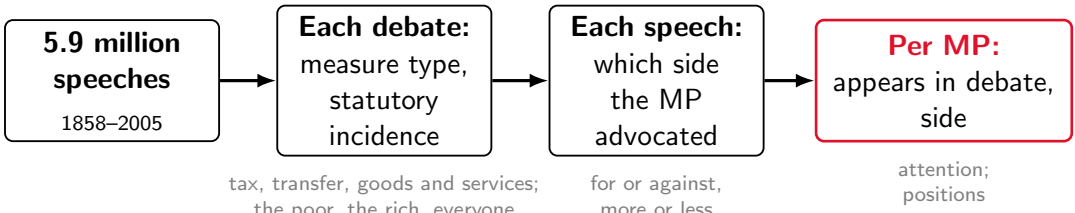
If no probate, to a death. *Below threshold*: wealth-at-death under £10 in 1858, £5,000 by 1985

£785 **£11,800**

▸ Property types ▸ Coverage ▸ Summary statistics ▸ Thresholds ▸ Linking fathers

Red: in 2010 prices.

Parliamentary speeches. Substantive representation





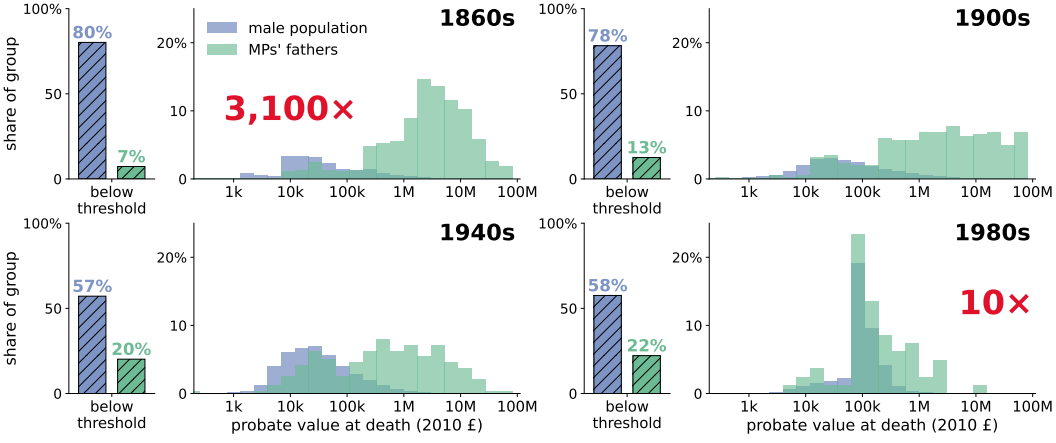
Government bills, 62% Private members' bills, 6% Questions and motions, 32%

▸ How speeches are coded ▸ Codebook ▸ Motivating example

Outline

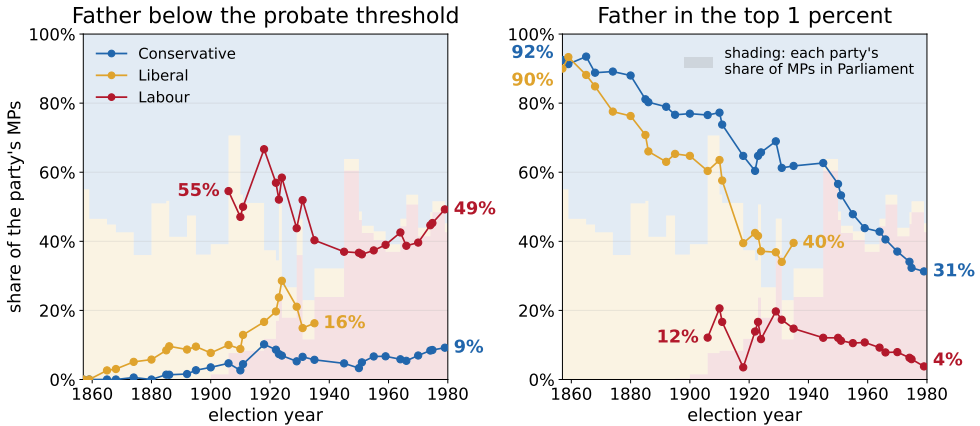
1. Historical Context and Data
2. Four facts about representation, 1858–1990
3. Did changes in franchise cause representation?
4. Did financial constraints keep poorer MPs out of politics?
5. Conclusion

Fact 1. The wealth gap between Parliament and the population fell from 3,100 to 10 times



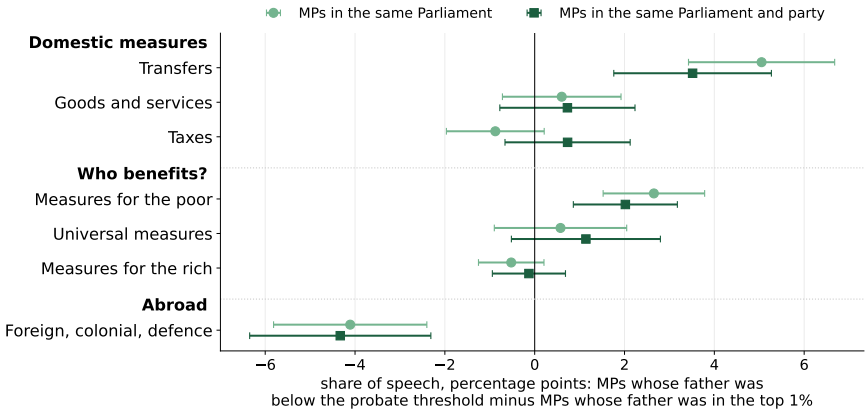
▸ Over-representation by group ▸ By party ▸ Other ways to measure gap

Fact 2. Poorer MPs entered Parliament through Labour and unions



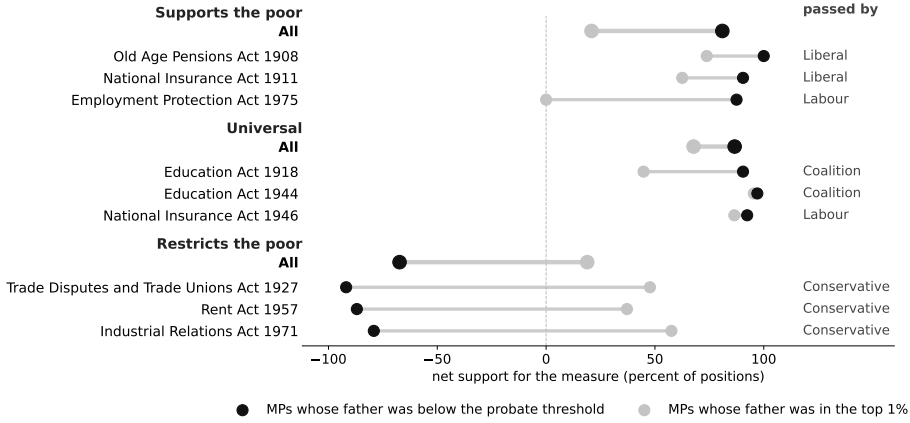
‣ Union sponsorship ‣ Below threshold relative to the population

Fact 3. Attention: MPs from poorer backgrounds were more likely to speak in debates for the poor



▸ By period ▸ By type of debate ▸ Own wealth? ▸ MPs debate what their voters care about

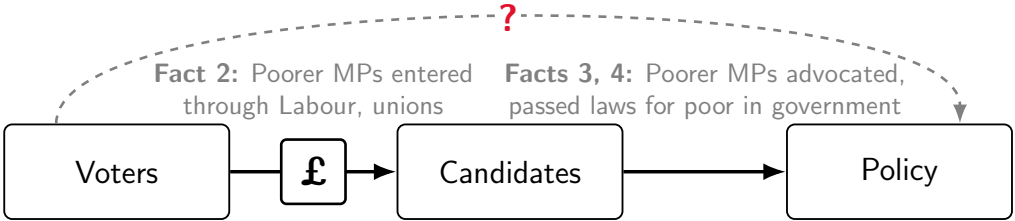
Fact 4. Position: MPs from poorer backgrounds advocated and passed pro-poor policies



‣ Acts passed ‣ Budgets ‣ By party ‣ Eligibility ‣ Middle group?

Did changes in franchise cause representation?

Test 3: or did voters change policy by changing how incumbent MPs behaved?



Fact 1: MPs' fathers' wealth
3,100× → 10× the population

Test 1 (cohorts)**:** did a wider franchise bring in MPs from poorer backgrounds?

Test 2 (constituencies)**:** did new voters support parties that put up poorer candidates?

Outline

1. Historical Context and Data

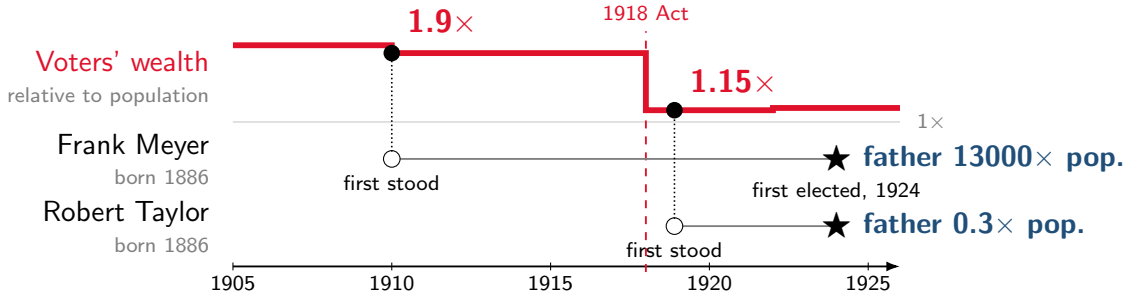
2. Four facts about representation, 1858–1990

3. Did changes in franchise cause representation?

4. Did financial constraints keep poorer MPs out of politics?

5. Conclusion

1. Did a wider franchise bring in MPs from poorer backgrounds?



$$M_i = \beta\, V_i + \lambda_{e(i)} + \phi_{a(i)} + \delta_{d(i)} + \varepsilon_i$$

M_i: MP i's father's wealth, relative to the population in the year he died

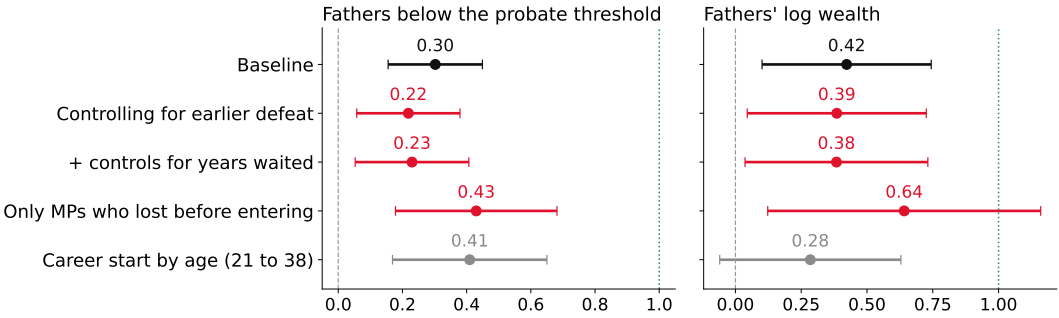
V_i: voters' wealth, relative to the population, when MP i first stood

λ: election of entry ϕ: five-year birth band δ: father's year of death

$\beta = 1$: MP fathers' wealth changed as much as voters' wealth changed; $\beta = 0$: not at all

▸ In the share of fathers below the probate threshold ▸ Dating careers by age

A wider franchise brought in MPs from poorer backgrounds

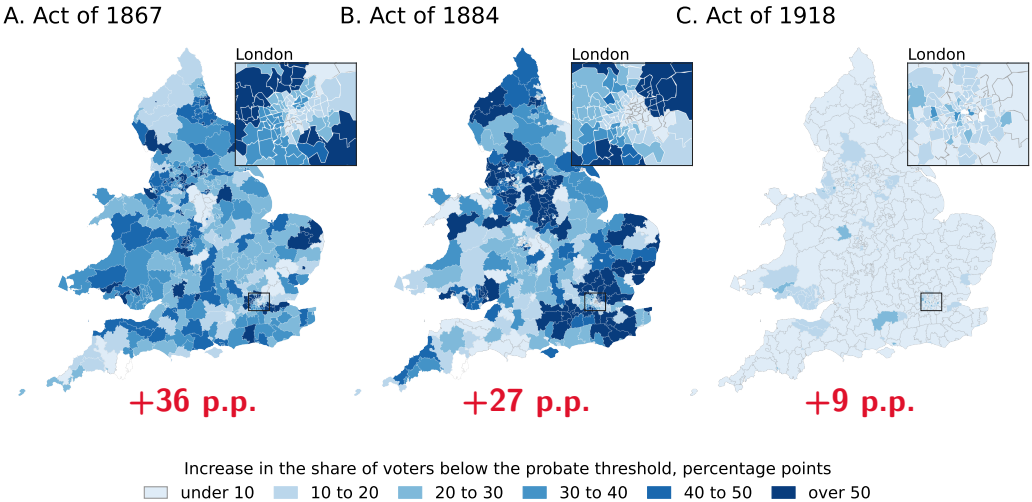


$\hat{\beta}$: change in MPs' fathers' wealth per unit change in voters' wealth (1 = one for one)

The franchise accounts for at least a third of the change in who was elected

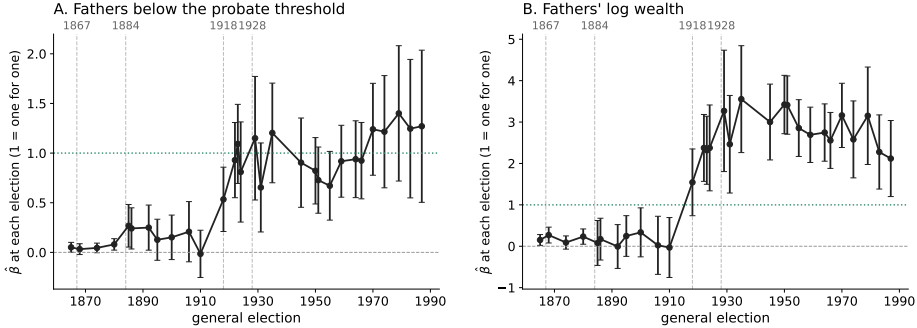
▸ Counterfactuals ▸ 1865 voters (Gallup) ▸ By Act ▸ By age at the Act ▸ Other datings

2. Did new voters back parties with poorer candidates?



Poorer voters elected MPs from poorer backgrounds

$$\underbrace{M_{c,t}}_{\text{constituency } c\text{'s MPs' fathers (share below threshold, log wealth)}} = \alpha_t + \underbrace{\beta_t}_{\text{one regression per election } t} \times \underbrace{V_{c,t}}_{\text{constituency } c\text{'s voters (share below threshold, log wealth)}} + \varepsilon_{c,t}$$



▸ By party ▸ Difference-in-differences ▸ Women admitted in 1918

3. Did voters affect how incumbent MPs behaved?

$y_{id} = 1$ if MP i takes the pro-poor side on policy measure d (as in Fact 4)
$V_{i,p(d)}$: share of their voters below the threshold in $p(d)$, the Parliament debating d

A different MP, the same voters: who is elected

$$y_{id} = \beta_M \underbrace{M_i}_{\text{father below threshold, vs top 1\%}} + \beta_V V_{i,p(d)} + \underbrace{\delta_d}_{\text{measure}} + \varepsilon_{id}$$

$$\bar{y}_c = \tau \, \text{Won}_c + f(\text{margin}_c) + \varepsilon_c$$

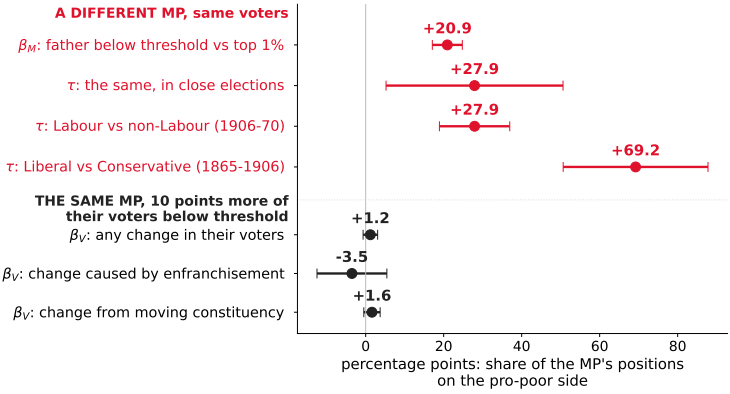
- Close elections: $\bar{y}_c$, mean y_{id} of constituency c's MP; wins vs losses within 10pt
- Candidate: Labour, Liberal (pre-1906), or father below threshold (minus top 1%)

The same MP, different voters: other channels

$$y_{id} = \beta_V V_{i,p(d)} + \underbrace{\alpha_i}_{\text{MP}} + \delta_d + \varepsilon_{id}$$

- $V_{i,p(d)}$ changes with local wealth over time, enfranchisement, or MP moving constituency

Enfranchisement affected policy by changing MPs

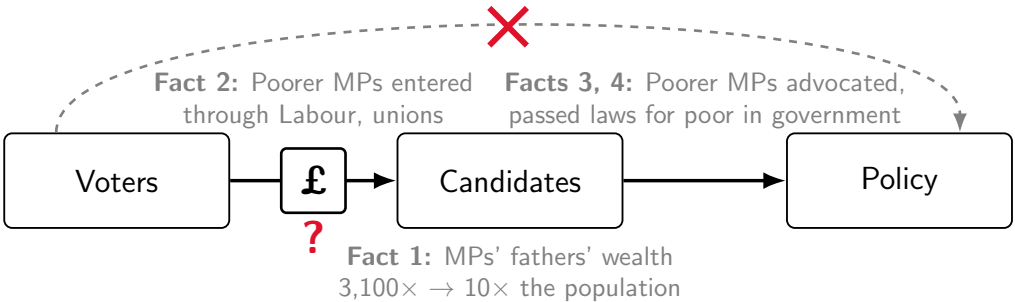


▸ Close elections: Labour ▸ Close elections: Liberals

▸ Attention ▸ Within party

Did financial constraints keep poorer MPs out of politics?

Test 3: incumbents did not change; policy changed through who was elected



✓ **Test 1:** a wider franchise brought in MPs from poorer backgrounds

✓ **Test 2:** new voters supported the parties that put up poorer candidates

Were financial constraints keeping poorer candidates out?

Outline

1. Historical Context and Data

2. Four facts about representation, 1858–1990

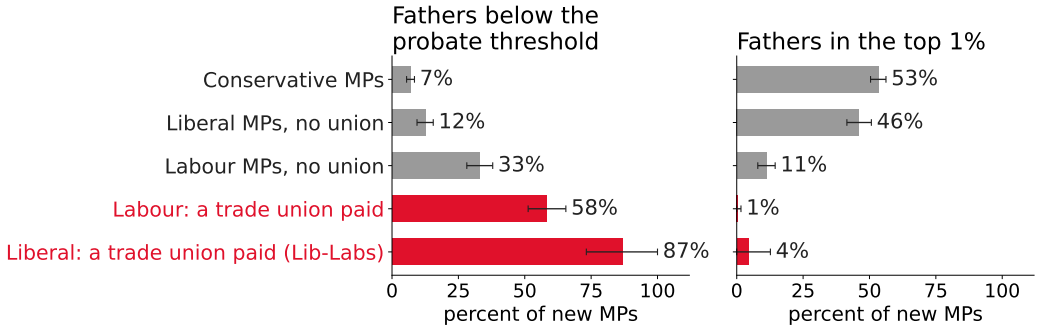
3. Did changes in franchise cause representation?

4. Did financial constraints keep poorer MPs out of politics?

5. Conclusion

Financing and representation

In 1885 a campaign cost £664.
This was more wealth than 95 percent of men left when they died.



‣ Union MP debates ‣ Inheritance ‣ Candidate wealth ‣ 1949 reforms ‣ Campaign costs

Outline

1. Historical Context and Data

2. Four facts about representation, 1858–1990

3. Did changes in franchise cause representation?

4. Did financial constraints keep poorer MPs out of politics?

5. Conclusion

Enfranchisement led to representation. Why it matters

- Universal suffrage taken for granted in democracies, but barriers to voting and candidacy remain prevalent
- Britain — enfranchisement helped end plutocracy due to successful organisation of poorer voters; similar movements did not always form
- US — no labour political organisation: gap in legislators' backgrounds somewhat widened, 1860s–1990s (Feigenbaum et al. 2026)
- Today — financial barriers continue to rise: US federal elections cost $3.1bn (2000) and $14.4bn (2020); top 0.01% of voting-age population donations went from 10% (1980) to 40% (2012), Citizens United.
  Full representation unlikely

Democracy can work, but who can stand decides who is represented

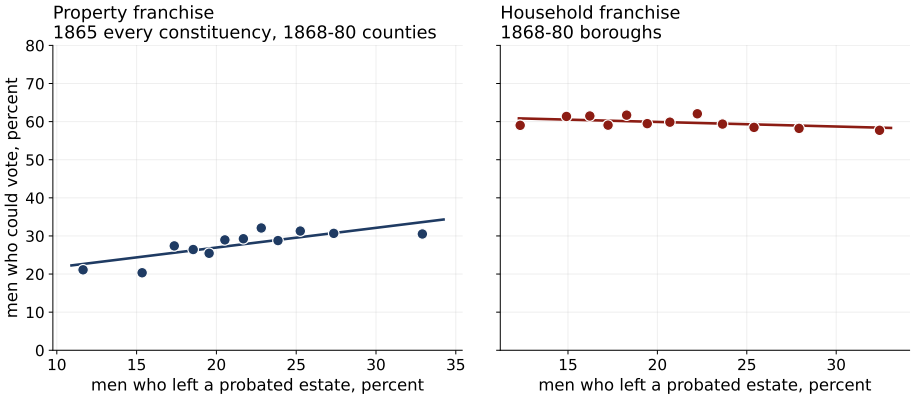
Further research

- **With this data & thesis.**
  - **Wealth and Political Dynasties:** do political families keep power through inherited wealth or political capital? The relative premium to wealth has fallen, while the relative premium to becoming a politician has risen.
  - **Pecuniary Selection or Incentives:** separating who can afford to stand from returns to own wealth-at-death to understand why people become politicians.
- **On representation.**
  - Prospect of representation $\Rightarrow$ political movements?
  - Non-financial barriers to selection
  - Trade-offs with other dimensions of identity

Thank you

g.praninskas@lse.ac.uk
gailius.praninskas.com

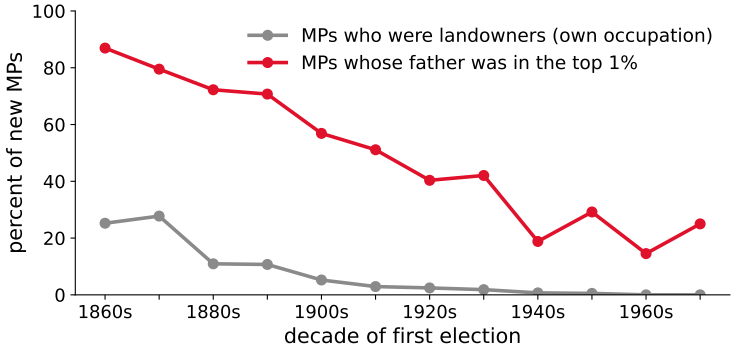
Property franchise: more probated men, more voters



Constituencies in 12 equal groups by the share of men who left a probated estate. Line: all constituencies.

back

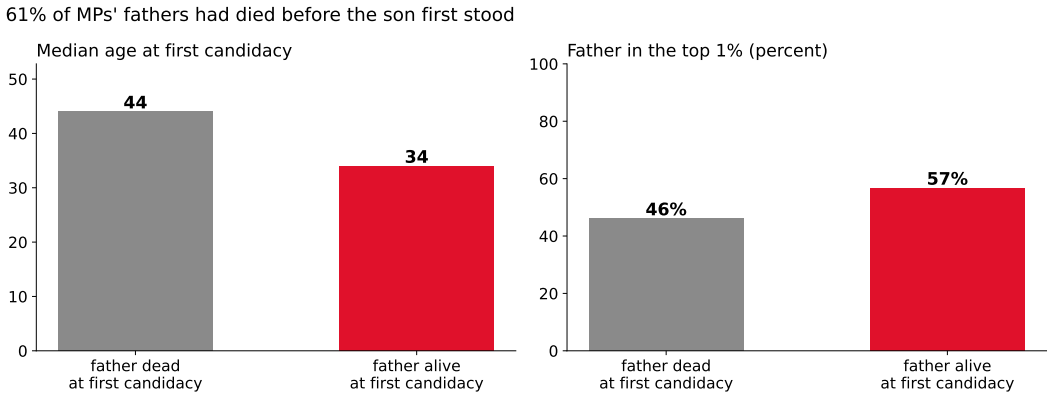
New MPs, 1860s to 1910s: landowners; fathers in the top 1%



New MPs by decade of first election. Occupation: the MP's own formative occupation (Rush).

back

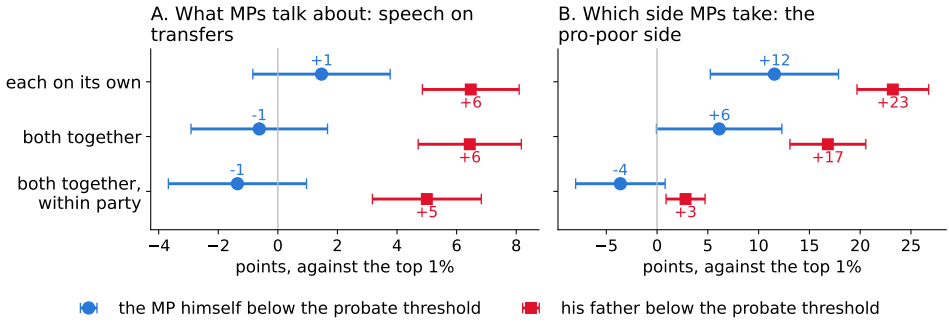
Three in five fathers had died before the son first stood



4,814 MPs with the father's year of death and a first candidacy, 1832–1990.

back

Father's wealth is a better predictor of MP debate than own wealth



3,423 MPs. Below probate threshold against the top 1% of the death-year population, for the MP and for their father. Speech: same Parliament; positions: same measure; s.e. by MP.

back

What's included in probates?

	1858–1897	1898–1925	1926–1990
Unsettled personalty: money, shares, goods	✓	✓	✓
Unsettled realty: land and houses	–	✓	✓
Settled realty: land held in a settlement	–	–	✓
Settled personalty: property held in trust	–	–	–

Years	Change	Median estate (2010 £)	99th percentile (2010 £)	Probates	Probated (% of deaths)
1895–1897	1898: unsettled realty enters	26,138	4.0m	169,575	19.0
1898–1900		35,703	4.6m	191,824	19.7
Change		*+37%*	*+15%*	*+13%*	*+0.7 pts*
1923–1925	1926: settled land enters	22,909	1.9m	307,492	28.6
1926–1928		25,917	2.0m	335,218	29.9
Change		*+13%*	*+5%*	*+9%*	*+1.2 pts*

Three years before and after each change.

▸ Excluded property

◂ back

Property excluded from probates

Gifts before death: a gift escaped death duty if made more than ... before death

1858–1880	any time: gifts not taxed	1946–1967	5 years (from 1960, years 3–5 partly)
1881–1888	3 months (account duty)	1968–1974	7 years
1889–1893	1 year	1975–1980	never: lifetime gifts taxed when made
1894–1909	1 year (estate duty)	1981–1985	as above; last 10 years set the rate
1910–1945	3 years	1986–1990	7 years, tapered from year 3

Trusts: settled property missing from the probate statistics

1911	1926–28	1954	1961	1970s on
about 20%	about 5%	2.5%	0.5%	about 1%

Trusts: share of probates to 1928, of personal wealth after. Before 1914, settled property was already taxed through other means. Atkinson (2013), citing Campion, Lydall and Tipping, Revell; Customs and Inland Revenue Acts 1881, 1889.

back

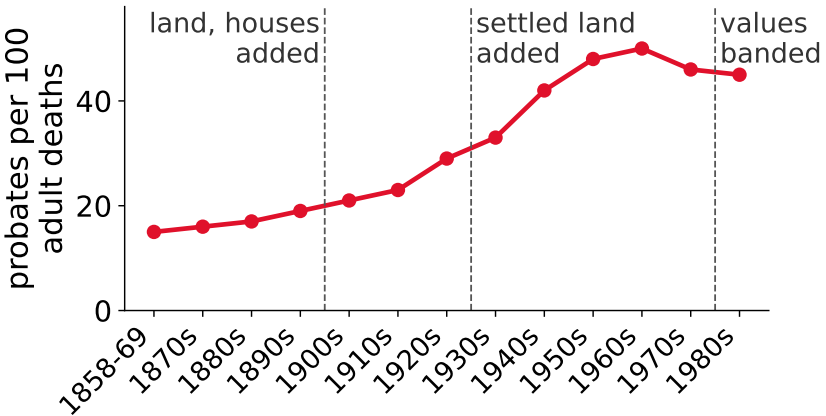
Probate values across the threshold changes

Years	Threshold	Threshold (2010 £)	Median estate (2010 £)	Probates	Probated (% of deaths)	Estates between old and new limit (%)
1898–1900	£10 → £50	847 → 4,234	35,703	191,824	19.7	5.9
1901–1903			35,066	193,206	20.7	6.1
Change			*-2%*	*+1%*	*+1.0 pts*	*+0.1 pts*
1929–1931	£50 → £100	2,707 → 5,414	29,720	381,749	31.4	4.2
1932–1934			33,679	401,069	32.5	4.1
Change			*+13%*	*+5%*	*+1.1 pts*	*-0.2 pts*
1962–1964	£100 → £500	1,510 → 7,551	23,938	837,727	52.8	22.1
1965–1967			30,725	765,981	48.4	12.0
Change			*+28%*	*-9%*	*-4.4 pts*	*-10.1 pts*
1972–1974	£500 → £1,500	3,271 → 9,814	39,142	816,873	47.8	21.3
1975–1977			37,197	787,347	46.0	11.7
Change			*-5%*	*-4%*	*-1.8 pts*	*-9.6 pts*
1982–1984	£1,500 → £5,000	3,545 → 11,815	78,293	823,857	48.7	2.5
1985–1987			94,777	709,961	41.6	1.2
Change			*+21%*	*-14%*	*-7.0 pts*	*-1.4 pts*

Three years before and after each change. Some values are banded from 1981.

back

Probate coverage over time



Probates and letters of administration per adult death, both sexes.

back

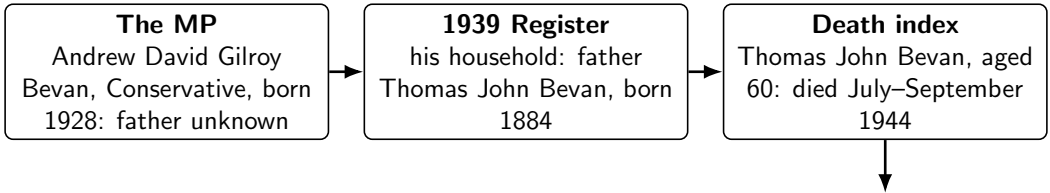
Probate summary statistics by decade

	Probate records	Mean probated estate (nominal £)	Mean probated estate (2010 £)	Probates per adult death
1858–1869	405,328	2,591	190,570	0.15
1870s	424,408	3,018	221,656	0.16
1880s	476,606	4,001	331,682	0.17
1890s	575,713	4,272	372,938	0.19
1900s	671,373	4,344	362,992	0.21
1910s	812,781	5,155	298,116	0.23
1920s	1,062,930	3,883	168,673	0.29
1930s	1,384,319	3,136	163,802	0.33
1940s	1,902,832	3,125	103,342	0.42
1950s	2,343,096	3,432	72,318	0.48
1960s	2,631,954	4,872	74,019	0.50
1970s	2,631,594	11,286	77,364	0.46
1980s	2,526,087	51,152	120,488	0.45
1990	241,147	121,149	214,757	0.43

Means are among probated records. Probates per adult death: ages 21 and above, both sexes.

back

Linking MPs' fathers



Probate found	Below threshold	Died before 1858	Scotland, Ireland, abroad	Other	Still being traced
51%	**9%**	**23%**	**8%**	**1%**	**8%**

Fathers of all 6,346 MPs who died by 2024. Other: father died after 1995, royal.

back

Classifying speech (debates)

1. **Speeches.** Every Commons speech, 1858–2005. Each speaker matched to one MP by name, date and constituency: 5.9 million speeches.
2. **Debates.** Each speech sits under a debate title. Bare headings ("Clause 3", "Committee", "Supply") are traced to the Bill or vote above them.
3. **Each title is coded** by LLM according to a codebook: the measure (Act or Bill and year), its type (tax, transfer, goods and services, machinery of the state; none for foreign affairs or procedure) and its statutory incidence (poor, rich, everyone).
4. **Statutory incidence** comes from the Act's eligibility: means test, manual workers, tenants = poor; owners of land or capital = rich; all citizens, children, insured persons = everyone. Taxes by who pays.
5. **Coverage and checks.** The 136,000 largest titles, 80% of speech. 4,500 coded twice independently: same type 96%, same group 95%. Robust to classifying by keywords instead.

▸ Positions

◂ back

Classifying speech (MPs)

6. **Attention (Fact 3).** Each MP in each Parliament with at least 20 classified speeches (99% of all classified speech; results robust to weighting or no minimum speech count): share of speech on each type of measure and on measures for each group. MPs whose fathers were below the probate threshold against those whose father was in the top 1%, same Parliament, and same Parliament and party.

7. **Positions (Fact 4).** One unit = all of one MP's speech on one measure on one day. LLM reads it and records: for, against or no side; objection that it does too little or too much; argues to widen or narrow eligibility. 185,000 units.

8. **Siding with the poor.** Each measure for the poor is coded from the statute as *extending* what the poor receive (pensions, 1908) or *restricting* it (means test, 1934). MP sides with the poor if they support an extension, or if they oppose a restriction.

9. **Checks.** Units coded twice independently are coded as taking the same side 97% of the time.

back

The codebook

Measures		
Tax	taxes, duties, rates	Finance Act 1894
Transfer, direct	money or goods to households	Old Age Pensions Act 1908
Transfer, indirect	law moving income between private parties: unions, rents, wages	Trade Disputes Act 1906
Goods and services	in-kind state provision	Education Act 1944
Machinery of the state	courts, local government, elections	Local Government Act 1888
Everything else	foreign affairs, defence, procedure	
Statutory incidence		
The poor	a means test, manual workers, tenants	Unemployment Assistance Act 1934
Everyone	all citizens, children, insured persons	National Health Service Act 1946
The rich	owners of land, property or capital	Agricultural Rates Act 1896

◂ back

MPs from poorer backgrounds advocated for the poor
Jock Stallard

Jock Stallard, Labour, St Pancras North, 20 November 1973

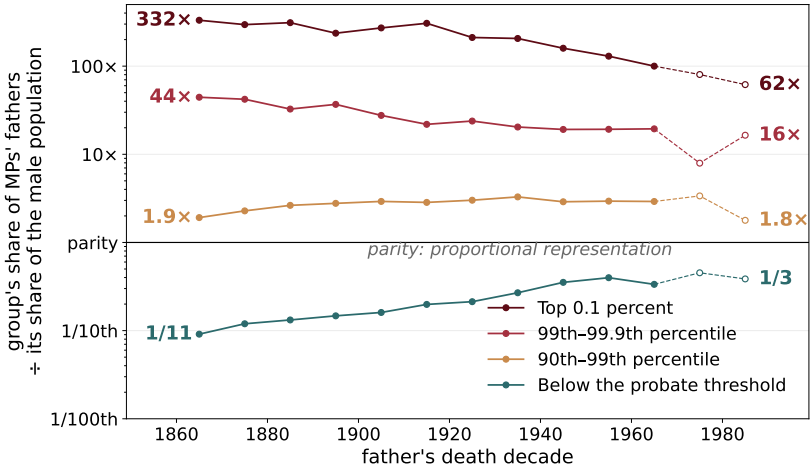
Conservative Members still do not accept that a two-bed roomed flat in an old converted house in my constituency costs between £12,500 and £17,000. They do not realise that no postman or bus driver in my constituency could buy such a flat.

Stallard was "the son of Frederick Stallard, a postman and driver from Tottenham", who died in 1972 leaving £1996 — in the 70th percentile of men dying in that decade

◂ back

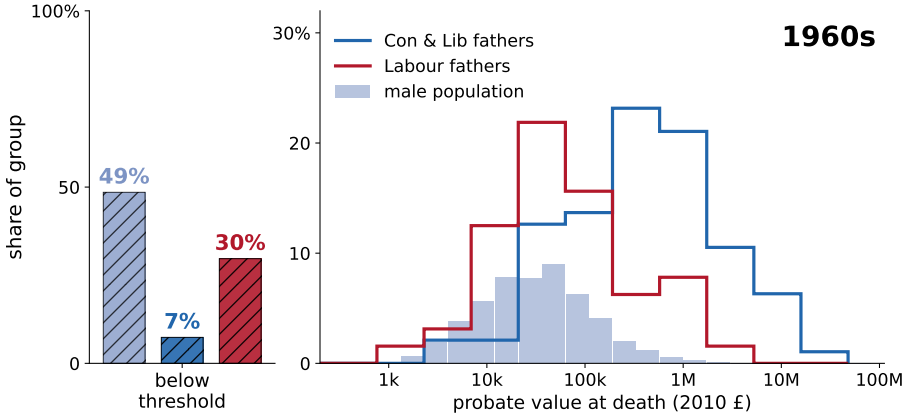
HC Deb 20 November 1973, vol. 864, col. 1176.

Over-representation of each wealth group among MPs' fathers



back

Fathers' probate values by party, 1960s



back

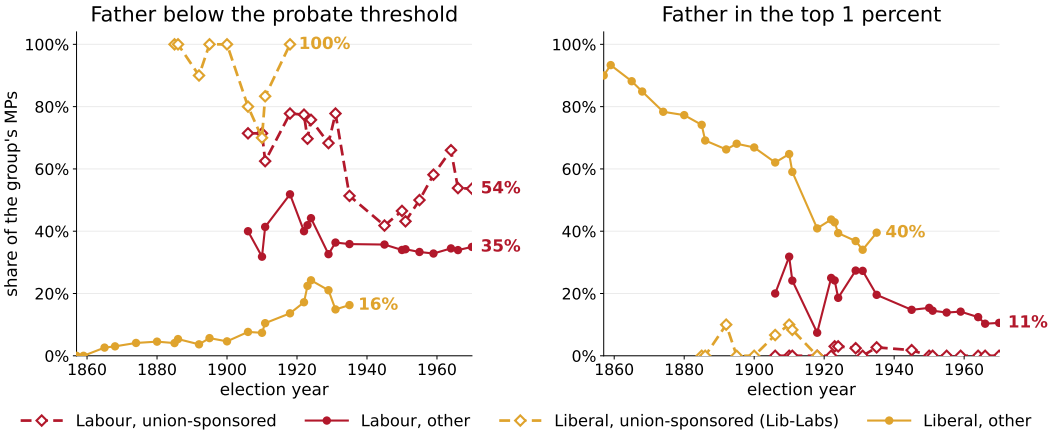
The wealth gap measured in five ways

MPs' fathers vs all men	1860s	1980s	Decline
Gap in mean log wealth (Fact 1)	**3,059×**	**9.6×**	**319-fold**
below threshold valued like small voluntary probates	2,953×	9.3×	316-fold
below threshold all valued at the threshold	1,476×	6.7×	219-fold
Gap in mean wealth	172×	8.0×	21-fold
Gap in mean log wealth, only those who were probated	64×	2.0×	32-fold

Gap: 10 to the power of the difference in means (log wealth) or the ratio of means (wealth). Fathers are richer at every rank, so the log gap equals the earth mover's distance. Fact 1 values men below the threshold evenly from £0 to the threshold. By decade of death; all men 21+; 2010 pounds.

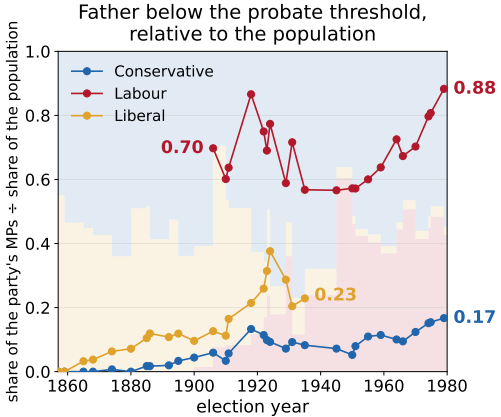
back

Wealth of union-sponsored and other MPs over time



back

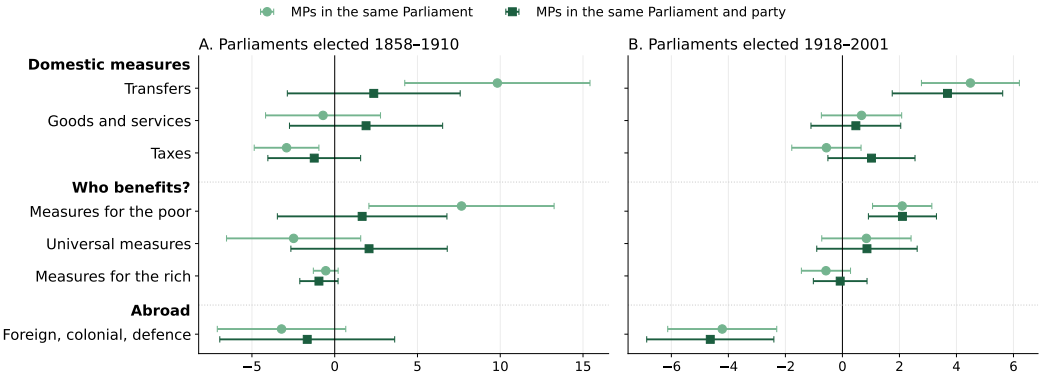
Below threshold fathers by party, relative to all men



1 = the same share as all men who died in the fathers' decade.

back

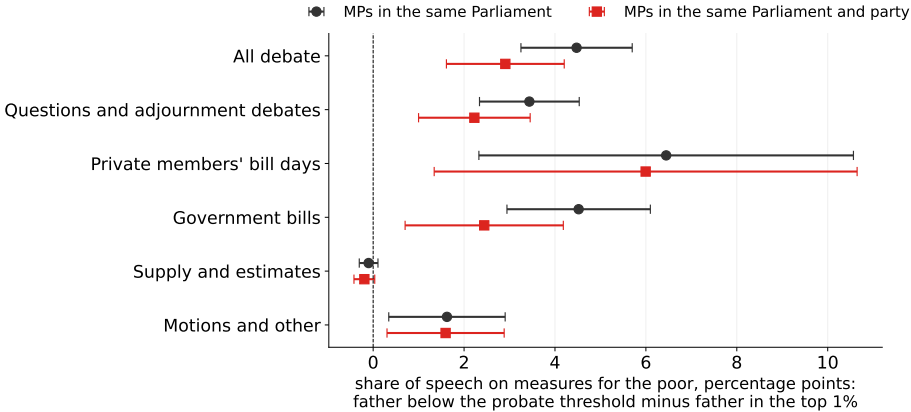
Attention before and after 1918



share of speech, percentage points: MPs whose father was below the probate threshold minus MPs whose father was in the top 1%

back

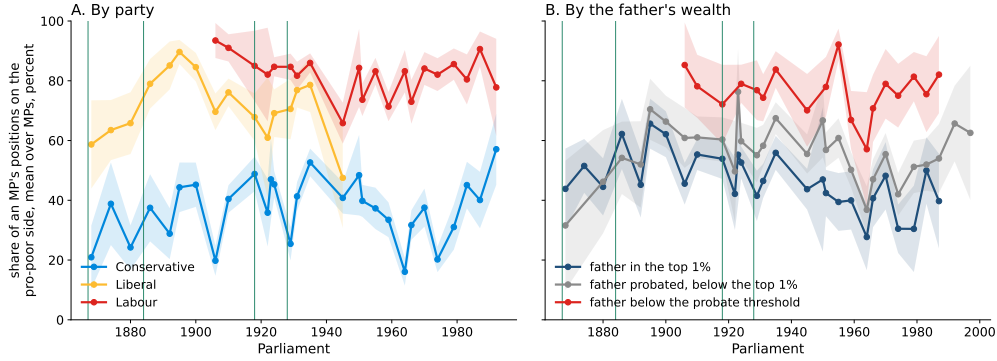
Attention to measures for the poor, by type of debate



MPs are less likely to be whipped on Questions, adjournment debates and private members' bill days.

back

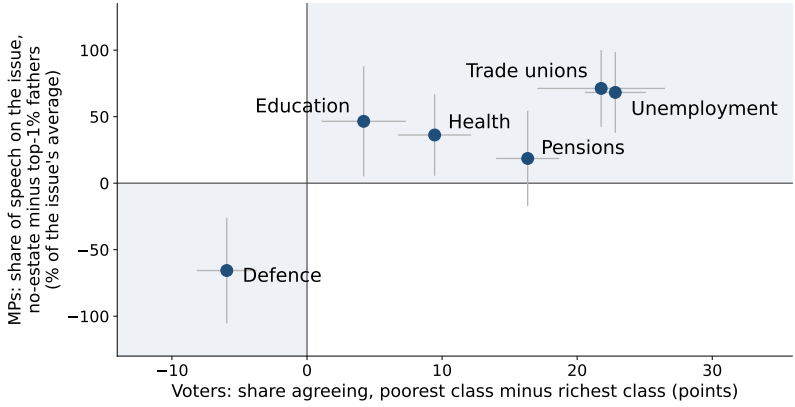
Which side MPs argued for, by party and by father's wealth



Share of an MP's pro-poor positions.

back

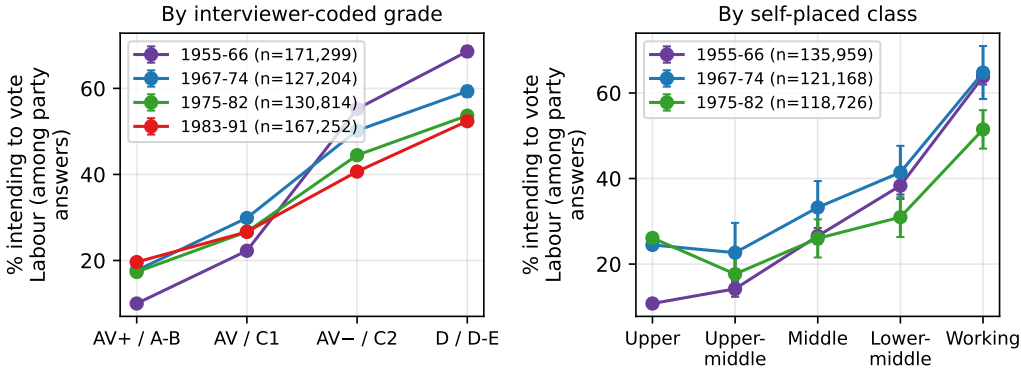
MPs with poorer fathers spoke about what poorer voters wanted



Gallup polls, 1961–1991, poorest minus richest class. MPs: share of speech on the issue, same Parliament.

‣ Class voting, 1955–91 ‣ By generation ◂ back

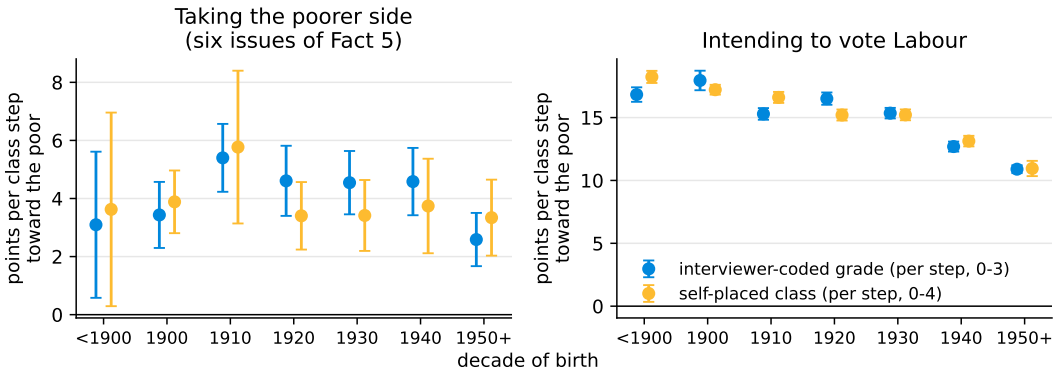
Class and Labour support, 1955–91



Poll, age-band and sex controls; base class at its raw mean.

back

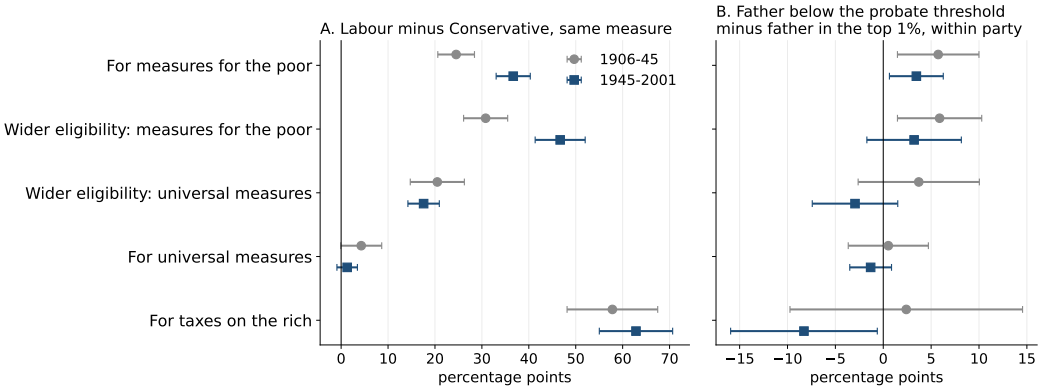
What poorer voters wanted, by generation



Gallup, 1955–91. Class by birth-cohort interactions with poll, age-band and sex controls; left: the six issues, pooled.

back

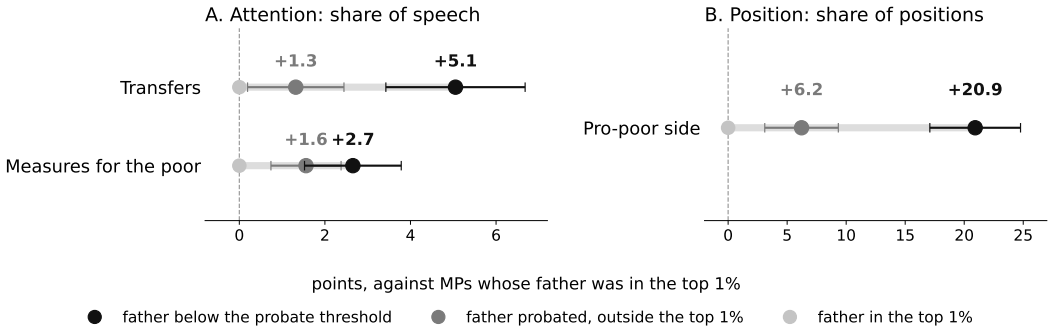
Pro-poor or universalist? Labour and poorer MPs argue for wider eligibility



"Reach more people" = argued for wider rather than narrower eligibility (13% of positions). S.e. by MP.

back

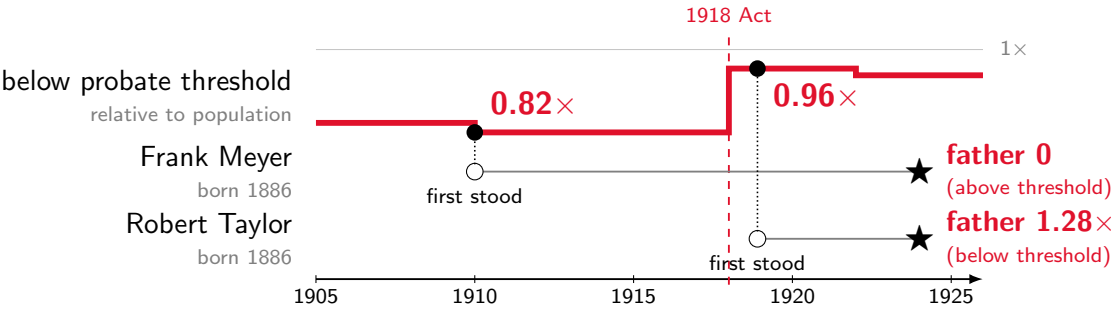
MPs whose fathers were in the middle sit closer to the top 1%



Attention: between MPs in the same Parliament (as Fact 3). Position: between MPs on the same measure (as Fact 4). 95% intervals, s.e. by MP. Within party: transfers +3.5 and +1.0; pro-poor side +1.7 and +0.9.

back

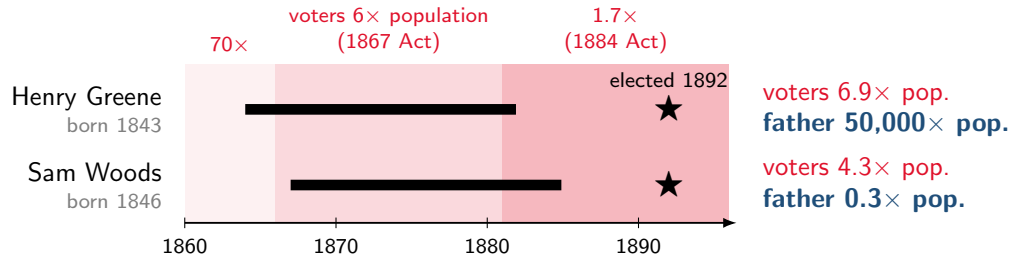
Test 1 in the share of below probate threshold fathers



Voters: their share below probate threshold at each election, divided by the population's share. Father: 1 if he was below the probate threshold at death, divided by the population's share in the father's year of death. Results hold without scaling by the share of the population below the threshold.

back

Careers by age: voter wealth over each MP's ages 21 to 38



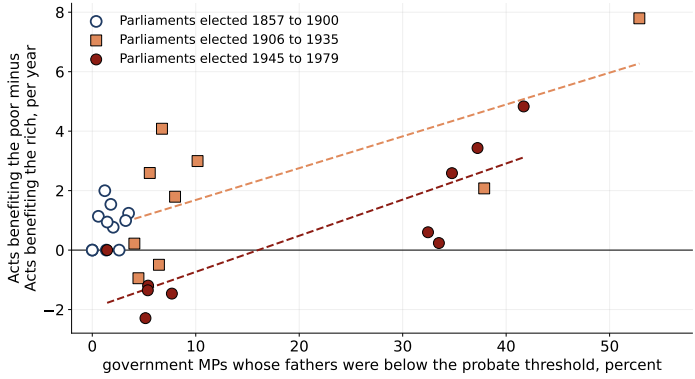
$$M_i = \beta \, \overline{V}_{i,\,21\text{–}38} + \lambda_{e(i)} + \phi_{a(i)} + \delta_{d(i)} + \varepsilon_i$$

$\hat{\beta}$: 0.28 (0.18) for log wealth; 0.41 (0.12) for the share below the probate threshold

Black bars: when each MP was aged 21 to 38. $\overline{V}$: voters' wealth relative to the population at the next election, averaged over those ages. Same controls as Test 1.

back

Acts benefiting the poor and who governed

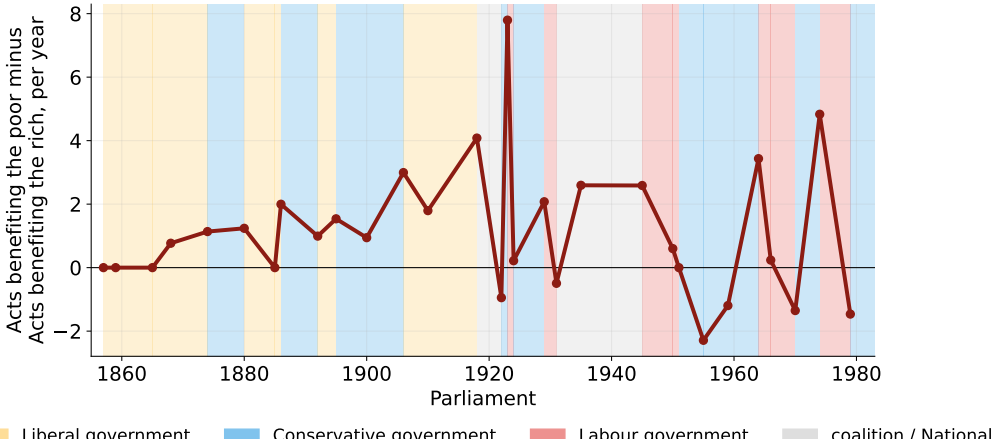


Passed domestic Acts. Benefiting the poor: extends what the poor receive or raises revenue from the rich.

‣ Timeline by Parliament

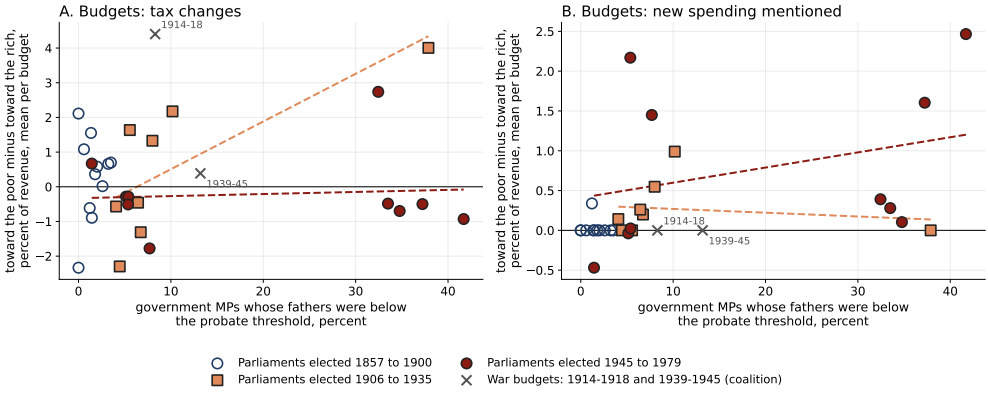
‣ back

Acts benefiting the poor, by Parliament



back

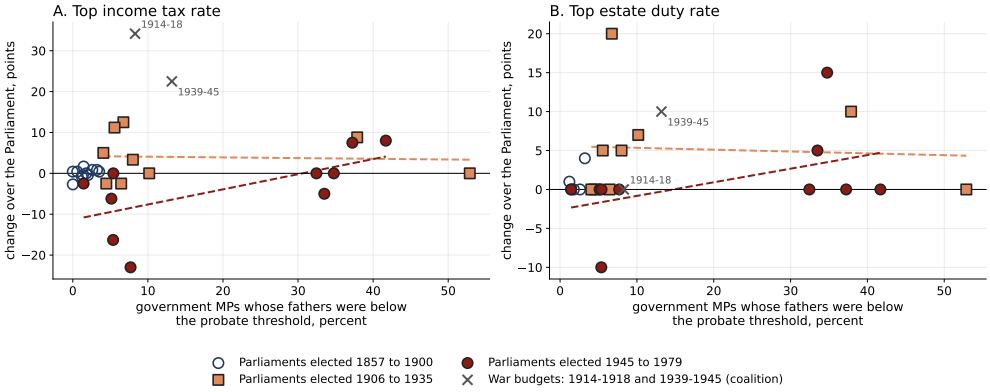
Budgets, by share of below threshold MPs in government



Each point is a Parliament, data is from Chancellors' budget statements.

▸ How budgets are coded ▸ Top tax rates ◂ back

Top tax rates, by share of poor in government



Each point is a Parliament: change in the top rate over the years whose budgets it set. Income tax includes super-tax and surtax; estate duty from the statutory schedule.

back

How budgets are coded

Source: every Budget statement, 1858–2005. Announced revenue or costs for each change (£m, full year).

Who pays, or who gains

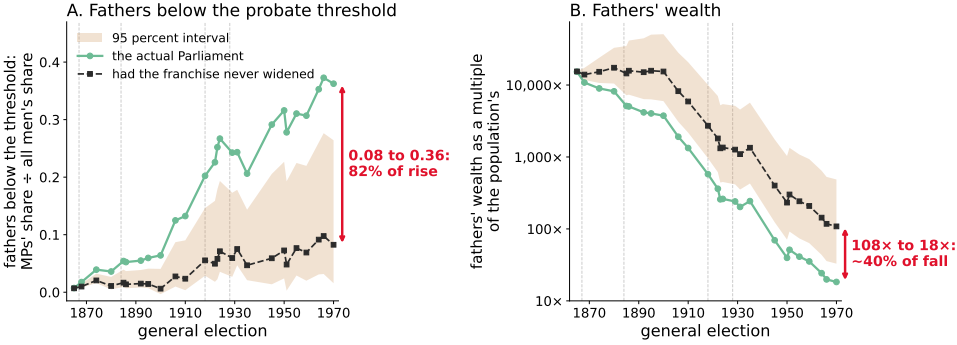
The rich pay	estate duty, surtax and higher rates, profits, land, capital gains; the standard rate before 1941	raised: toward the poor
The poor pay	beer, spirits, tobacco, food, tariffs, purchase tax and VAT; national insurance before 1975	raised: toward the rich
The poor gain	pensions, benefits, allowances for low incomes	more: toward the poor
Everyone	the standard rate from 1941, national insurance from 1975, general allowances, other spending	neutral

Each budget: tax changes and new spending, each $\sum$ sign $\times$ yield, percent of central government revenue

		Taxes	Spending
1909	estate, legacy and super-tax +£9.7m, land and stamp +£2.0m; spirits, tobacco, licences −£6.5m	+4.4%	0
1979	VAT to 15% −£4.2bn, top rate 83 to 60% −£1.1bn; pensions uprating +£2.7bn	−7.1%	+3.7%

back

Franchise accounts for at least a third of change in the elected

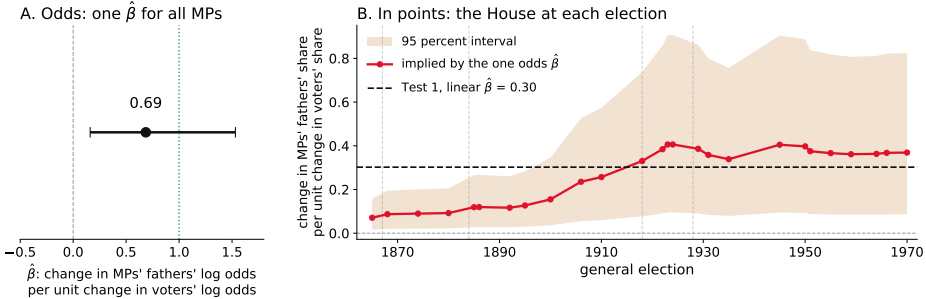


Had the franchise never widened: each sitting MP is given the voters of the 1832 franchise. Below threshold: logit with Test 1's controls, so the share cannot go below zero (Test 1's $\hat{\beta}$ gives 77%). Wealth: $\hat{\beta}$ from Test 1. Change from 1865–80 to 1970; band: bootstrap over years of birth.

▸ Pass-through in odds

◂ back

Logit estimates for no probate fathers

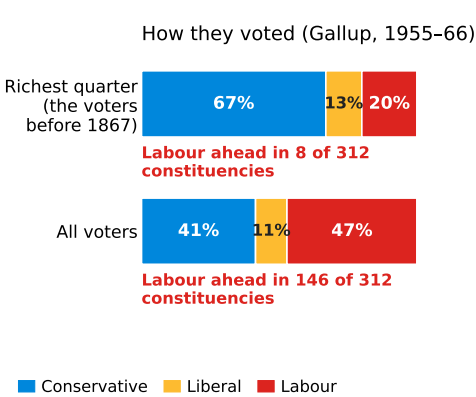


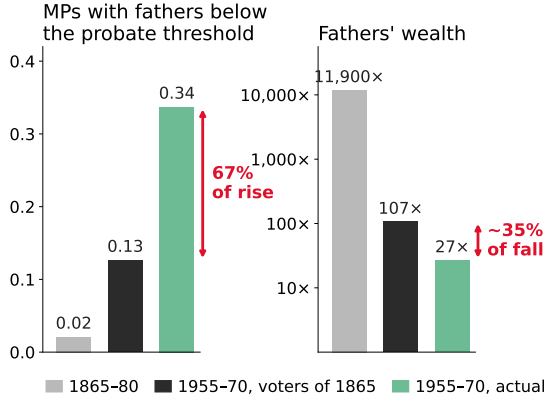
$$\log \frac{P_i}{1-P_i} = \beta \log \frac{v_i}{1-v_i} + \lambda_{e(i)} + \phi_{a(i)} + \delta_{d(i)}$$

P_i: chance that MP i's father was below the threshold; v_i: voters' share below it when he first stood. Test 1's fixed effects; 3,367 of 3,641 MPs (groups in which no father, or every father, was below drop out). In points: mean over the MPs sitting at each election. Band: bootstrap over years of birth.

back

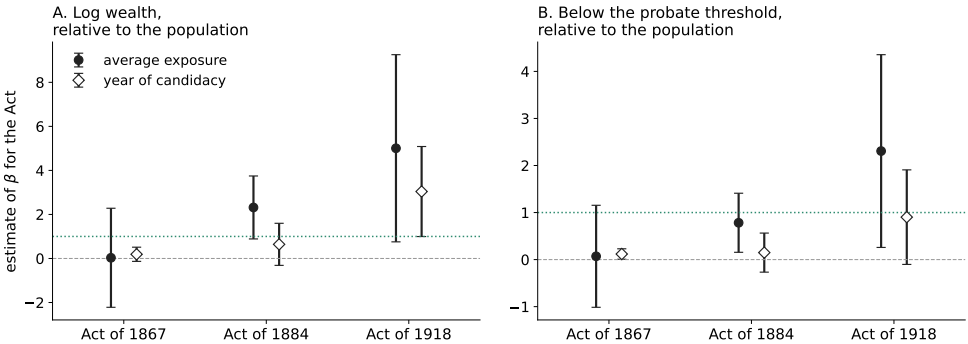
What would the voters of 1865 elect in 1955?





back

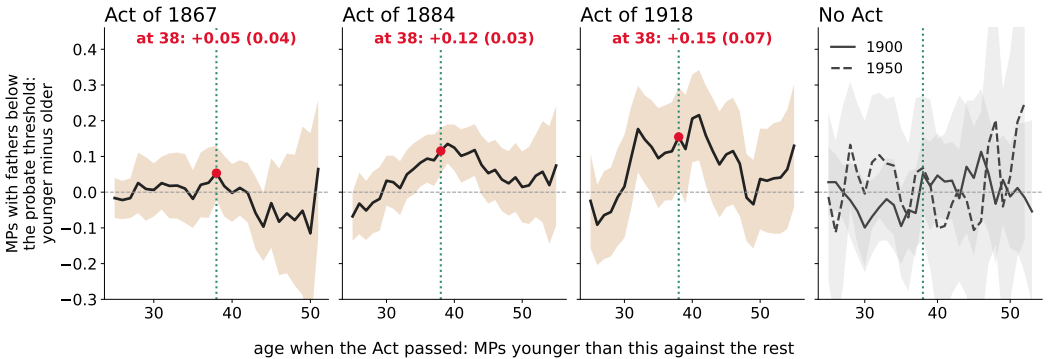
MPs who started under a wider franchise, Act by Act



β: share of each Act's change in voters wealth seen among new MPs.

back

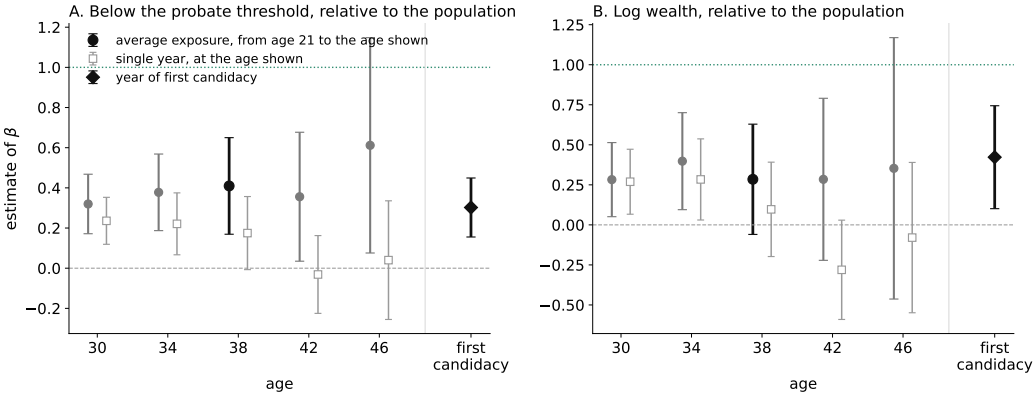
MPs who were young when an Act passed, against older MPs



MPs entering Parliament after each Act. Election, age band and father's year-of-death FEs; 95% bands. 38 is the median age at first candidacy.

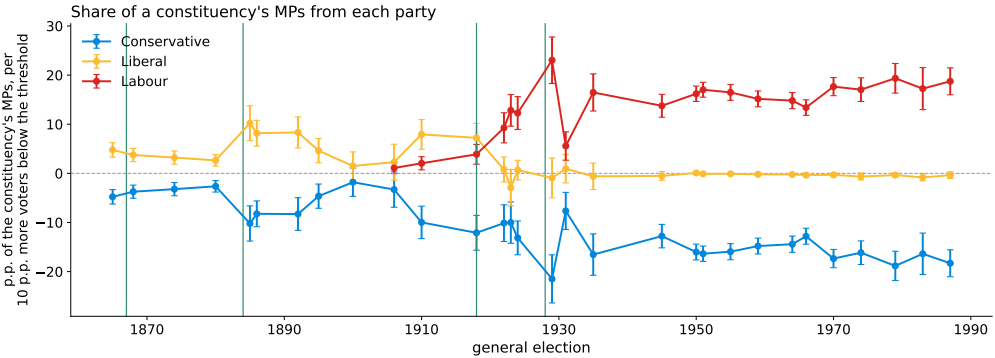
back

Other ways of dating a political career



back

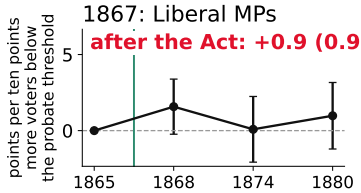
Poorer voters elected Liberals, then Labour

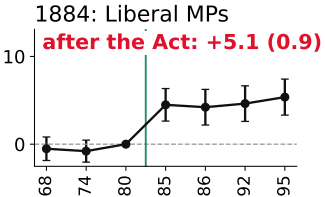


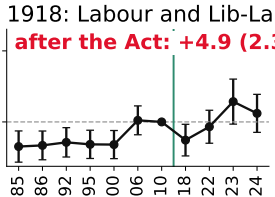
Each point: one general election, constituencies of 1918. Voters as in Test 2: share below the threshold relative to the population's share (1 = the same).

back

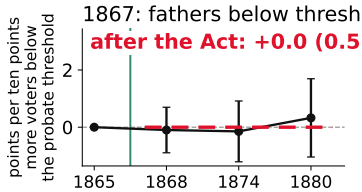
Newly enfranchised voted for parties with poorer representatives

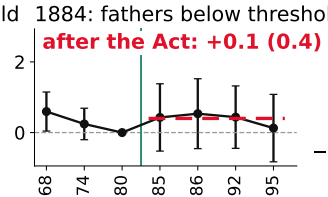


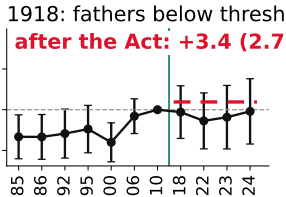




Party gap in below threshold **+0.3 (1.1)** **+7.3 (2.1)** **+38.7 (5.2)**







--- implied by the constituencies that changed party × party wealth gap

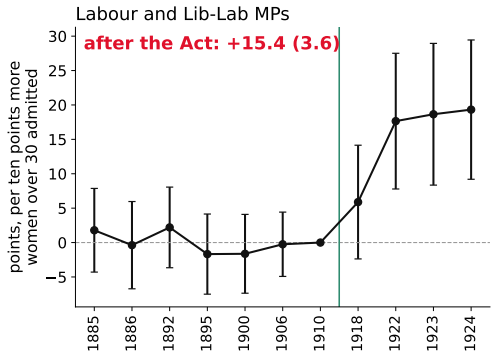
back

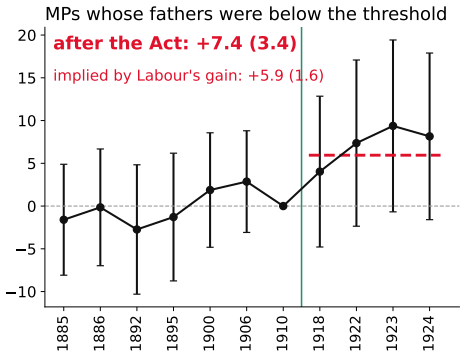
More women admitted in 1918 led to Labour wins, poorer MPs

3/4ths of women enfranchised (householders and wives) in 1918 were below threshold.

$$y_{ct} = \alpha_c + \delta_t + \sum_{k \neq 1910} \beta_k W_c \mathbf{1}\{t = k\} + \sum_k \gamma_k S_c \mathbf{1}\{t = k\} + \varepsilon_{ct}$$

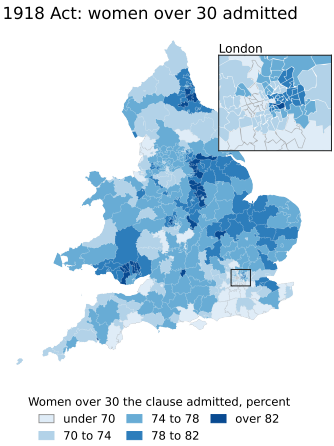
y_{ct}: Labour or Lib-Lab MP, or MP's father below the threshold, constituency c, election t. W_c: of c's women over 30, the share the clause admitted (1911 census); S_c: women over 30 per man. S.e. by constituency.





‣ Map ‣ Labour candidacies ◂ back

Share of women over 30 admitted in 1918, by constituency

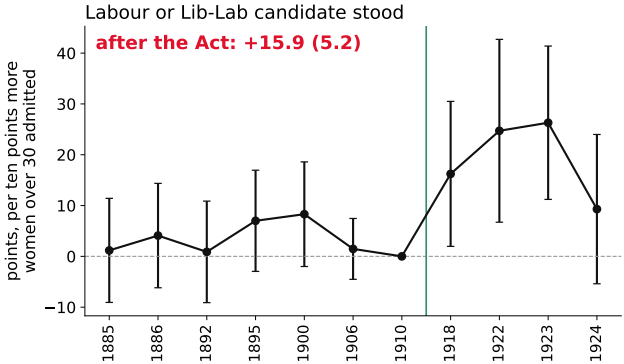


back

Women admitted in 1918 and Labour candidates

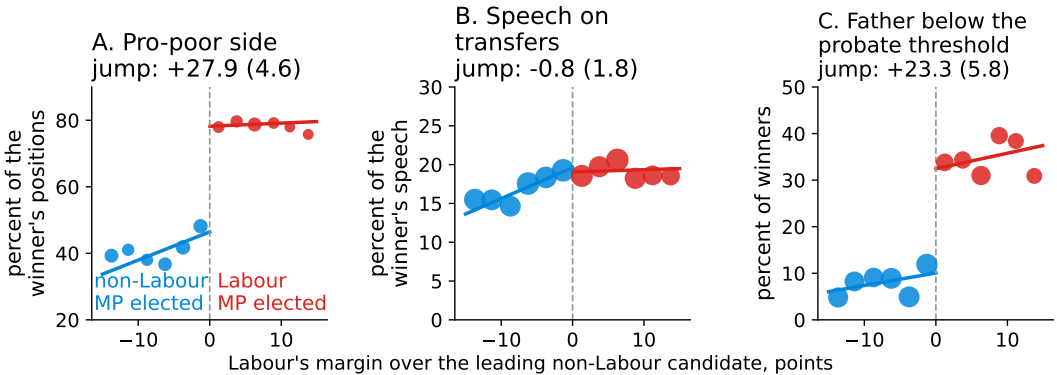
$$y_{ct} = \alpha_c + \delta_t + \sum_{k \neq 1910} \beta_k \, W_c \, \mathbf{1}\{t = k\} + \sum_k \gamma_k \, S_c \, \mathbf{1}\{t = k\} + \varepsilon_{ct}$$

y_{ct}: Labour or Lib-Lab stood



back

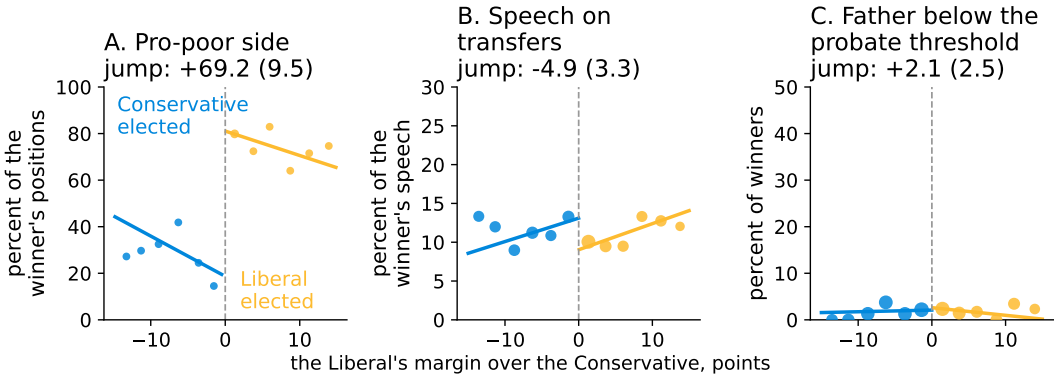
Close elections, Labour vs. Rest, 1906–70



General elections in single-member constituencies with a Labour and a non-Labour candidate as the two leading candidates; local linear fits within 15 points; jump estimated within 10 points, s.e. by constituency.

back

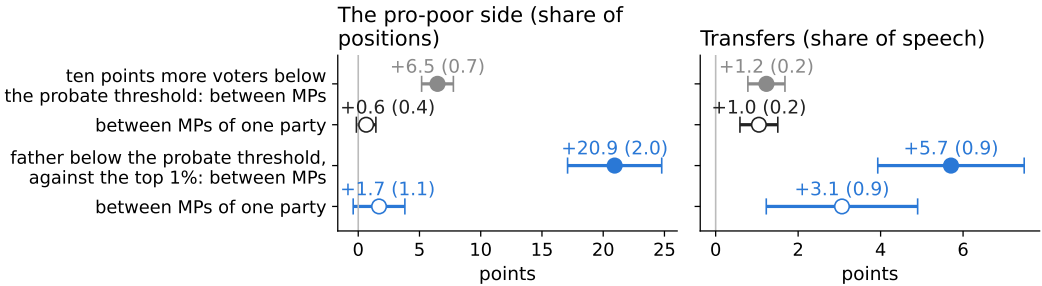
Close elections, Liberals vs. Conservatives, 1865–1906



General elections in single-member constituencies with a Liberal and a Conservative as the two leading candidates; positions exist for 124 of the races within 10 points, speech for 460.

back

Positions vs. attention within party

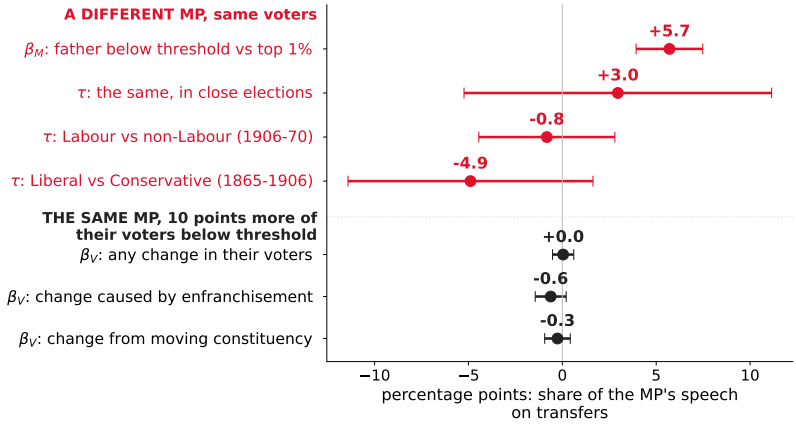


Between MPs: measure (positions) or Parliament (speech) effects; within a party: the same, interacted with party. S.e. by MP.

back

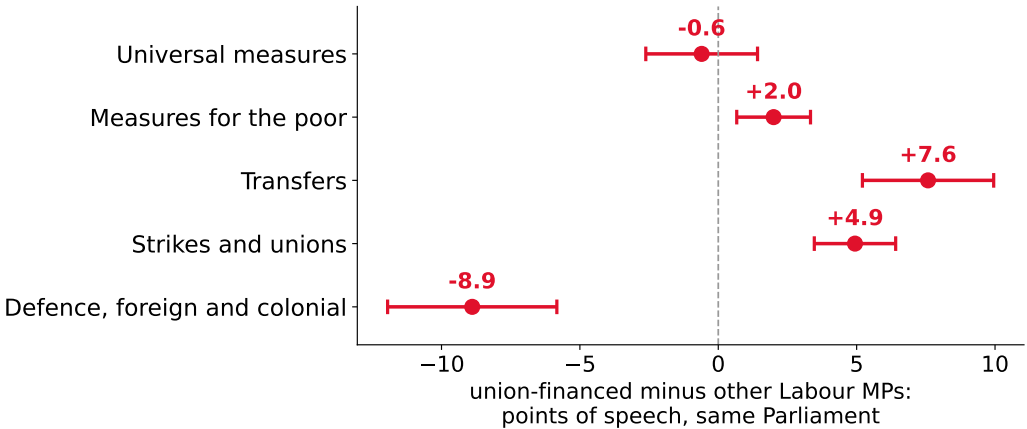
Attention follows MP fathers' wealth, not party or voters

The designs of Test 3, with a_{ip}, the share of MP i's speech on transfers in Parliament p (as in Fact 3), and Parliament effects in place of measure effects



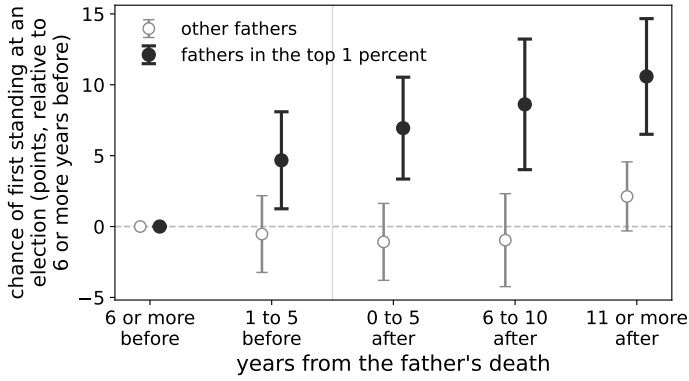
back

What did union-financed MPs talk about?



back

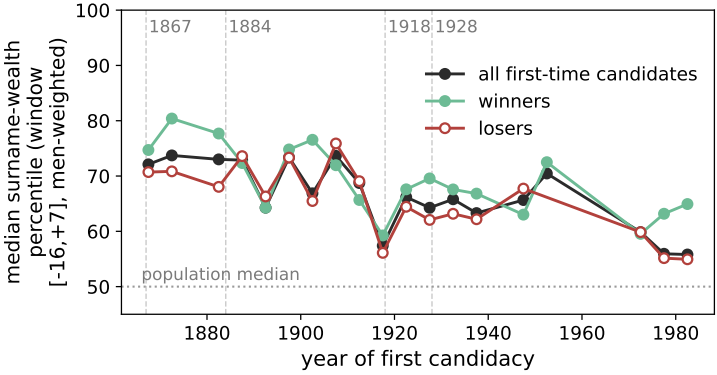
Inheritance only increases entry for the very wealthy



Excludes MPs whose fathers were themselves MPs or Lords; age and birth-decade effects; 95 percent intervals clustered by MP.

back

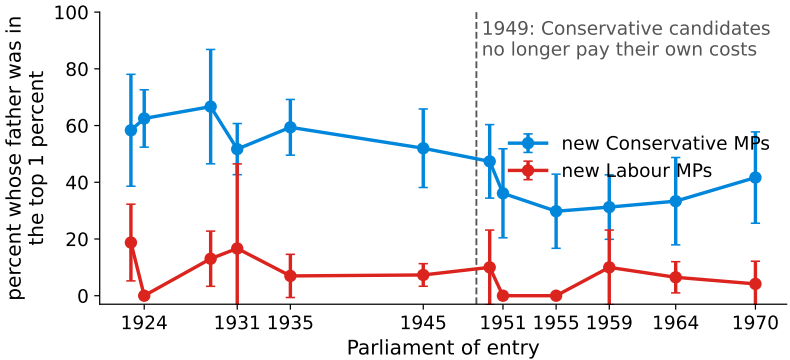
Candidate and MP surname wealth



Every first-time candidate 1865–1983 in the surname wealth distribution. Candidacy gap 14 points (64th against 50th percentile); winning gap 5.6.

back

Conservative Maxwell Fyfe Reforms

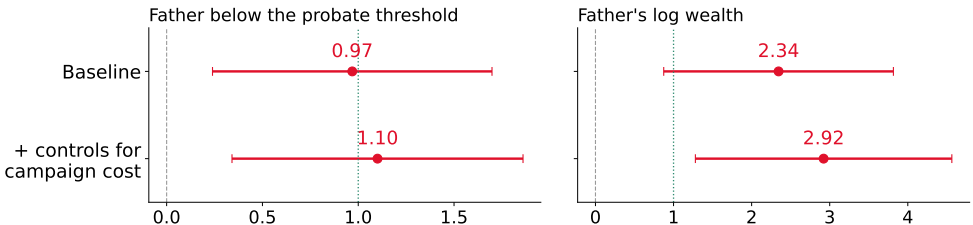


Conservative minus Labour change, 1935–66 entrants: −12.5 points (6.5).

back

The cost of a campaign against fathers' wealth

Real spending fell by 2/3rds 1910–22. 1/6th of its 1885 level by 1970.
Controlling for this, the franchise effect of Test 1 holds:



$\hat{\beta}$: share of the voters' change seen among new MPs

2,944 first-time MPs who first stood from 1885. Cost: average log real spending per major-party candidate at the election of first candidacy.

back